



**Apex mentality:** Ding Liren and Ju Wenjun await the respective winners of the men's and women's Candidates for their World Championship duels. LENNART OOTES & HARRY GIELEN

double-round robin format.

Tan Zhongyi was the world champion and the world rapid champion, while Lei Tingjie, Aleksandra Goryachkina, Kateryna Lagno, Anna Muzychuk and Koneru Humpy have all been losing finalists in the World Championship.

Muzychuk and Lagno have been World Rapid and Blitz champions as well. Humpy won the World Rapid in 2019 and narrowly missed winning it again in 2023. She plays fewer events nowadays, but she is able to compete at the highest levels and keep her strength.

Aleksandra Goryachkina won the FIDE World Cup last year. From their performances, I am unable to pick a favourite amongst these six

players. The two first-timers here are Vaishali and Nurgyul Salimova, who are also the two youngest participants.

Vaishali won the Grand Swiss last year and achieved the title of Grandmaster as well, leaving only Salimova without that title in the Candidates. Just like their male counterparts, their excitement can compensate for their lack of experience.

Vaishali can enjoy a historic moment together with her brother Praggnanandhaa as the first brother-sister pair in the Candidates!

I am confident that the Candidates tournament of 2024 will not disappoint in intensity or excitement.



**Since the Candidates tournament favours stability as much as ability, I lean towards Nakamura or Caruana as favourites.**